2038

CHAPTER ONE

AT FIVE O'CLOCK, the screen in front of Winston Reed presented its final two of the day.

Two corners. In the first, the ball was swung in hard and low and met by a defender who cleared it into the stands. In the second, the ball was swung in hard and low and met by nobody at all, and drifted out for a goal kick while the striker looked at the sky as though it had personally let him down.

Underneath was the usual question: Which do you prefer?

Reed preferred the second. It was worse football but better telly. He didn't know how the transistors got from his choice to the match on the box, and had never once felt the need to find out; he only knew that whatever he picked went into it somewhere, the way a brick goes into a wall, and that was good enough for him.

He selected it, and the screen went quiet.

It did not thank him. It never had. In eleven years it had said nothing to him but Which do you prefer?, a few hundred times a day, and then at five o'clock nothing at all, and Reed had come to think of this as good manners. The choices came as they came — some took him four seconds, some took him a quarter of an hour — and the only thing that ever answered back was the figures.

Eight hours. He stretched until something in his back clicked agreeably, and looked over the day's figures. They were good. They had been good since about Tuesday. There had been a dip around three, when he had chosen a penalty decision that most people apparently disagreed with, but Reed had watched both versions four times and remained of the view that the lad had gone down like a sack of spuds and deserved nothing. Being outvoted didn't make you wrong. It just meant everyone else was.

His best moment had come just before lunch: a goal. In one version the striker beat three defenders and placed it neatly in the top corner. In the other he beat only two, but the goalkeeper, diving the wrong way, managed somehow to fall over twice. Reed had laughed out loud at the second fall and chosen it without hesitation. Sooner or later that fall would turn up in the football somewhere, the way all his picks did, and when it did, Reed would know it was his. That was enough.

He put on his jacket, went out to the car, and told it the Crown.

The car was long and low and silver, with seats like good armchairs, and he had picked it in the spring from a list of about forty, mainly on the strength of the colour. He could have had any of them. Anybody could. Last year's had been red, and he had gone off red. It pulled away from the house without a sound and took him into town while he looked out of the window, which was the only part of driving Reed had ever really enjoyed.

Brackton on a weekday evening had the slightly smug air of a city that had been through something and come out the other side with better furniture.

The old mills along the canal had been turned into restaurants, climbing halls, a theatre, and a covered market that sold cheese of such variety that people argued about it. The mills still working worked quietly, turning out more in an afternoon than they had once managed in a month, and nobody standing outside them could have told you how. The pavements were clean. The trees along the canal had been planted by Mags — small, patient things that went about in the early mornings — and every one of them stood exactly where people had picked for it to go, so that the whole street looked as though somebody who loved trees had been given a free hand. Every house the car passed had its own

drive and its own garden and its own car outside, and nearly all of them were nicer than anything their owners had grown up in.

In the window of the old post office, now a café, half a dozen people sat at screens with the particular stillness of the working. One of them laughed suddenly and pointed, and the woman beside him leaned across to look at his screen, and nodded, as if to say yes, obviously, the first one. Further along, a Mag the size of a spaniel was seeing to a drain, and a small boy was watching it with his whole heart while his mother waited. The barber on Mill Street was still a man, and still talked all the way through, and it was generally held in Brackton that no Mag had yet managed either.

Most of the town was at it, one way or another. Eight in ten, somebody had said once on the telly, and Reed had believed it, because he would have struggled to name anybody who wasn't.

He remembered the year of the transistors — people still called it that, though it had been more like three — when they first started doing things that people had trained half their lives to do. First everyone was excited. Then everyone was frightened. By 2027 the fear had got into everything, the bus and the bar and the queue at the chemist, and every conversation came round in the end to which job had gone that week, and whose.

Reed had been frightened too, like everybody. He had a job then, and was good at it, the way most people were good at theirs, and every month there was something new the transistors could do, and every month it got harder to say what was left for anybody. He had never kidded himself he was special. He had only ever wanted to be useful, and paid, and home in time for the match, and for a year or two it had looked as though the first two were going the way of the horse.

Then one afternoon an offer had come through: eight hours a day, selecting football catalogs, for a proper wage. Cats, the offer called them, about halfway down, as though everybody already did.

He had assumed it was a scam. His roommate at the time had received one too — anime, in his case — and the two of them had sat at the kitchen table holding their offers side by side like men comparing parking tickets.

"They want me to pick which girl I prefer," his roommate said.

"That's not a job."

"I know."

"That's what you do anyway."

"I know."

They spent the evening trying to work out which of them was being conned worse. In the end they both tried it, mostly to find the catch. At the end of the month the money went into their accounts, the same as any other wage. Reed waited weeks for the catch to arrive, the way you wait for a punchline, and eventually stopped waiting.

"Get in," he had said, the morning he finally gave up on it, to nobody in particular. "Get in."

The rest took years. Bit by bit, more people took up Cat work — first the ones who had nothing else going, then the ones who had sworn blind they never would — and somewhere along the way the scores began to count for things. A table at a busy restaurant. A better seat at the match. Then the weekly shop. Then very nearly everything. Money hung about for a long while after anybody needed it, like the cheque book in the kitchen drawer, until one evening Reed realised he could not remember the last time he had paid for anything, and neither could anyone he asked.

His old roommate was still at it, picking between anime girls for a living and doing brilliantly. He had a house with a garden now and a car Reed had never seen the like of. The last message Reed had from him was a long paragraph about a character's hair that Reed had not understood a word of, but which radiated the contentment of a man who had found his calling and been rewarded for it ever since.

The Crown had been a pub for two hundred years and had survived the end of the world as it was by doing absolutely nothing differently, which was its great charm. Charleston and Benjamin were already in the corner under the telly, where they had been, in some sense, for years.

"Here he is," said Charleston. "Captain Football."

"Evening, lads."

"Good day?"

"Cracking day."

"Hard graft, was it?" said Benjamin. "Sat on your arse watching the match?"

"Eight hours of concentration, that is. You try it."

"I do try it. I do it with music."

"Music's easier. You can have it on in the background."

Benjamin pointed a finger at him. "Say that again and you're getting your own round."

Nobody got rounds anymore, but the threat had kept its shape, like a pub sign for a coaching inn where no coach had stopped in a century. Reed's pint arrived without his having asked for it, cold, the exact shade he liked, and he took a long first drink with his eyes closed.

The telly above them showed what it had always shown, which was football. It was one of the few screens left in Brackton that had to please a whole room instead of one person, and it managed, mostly, by not trying anything clever.

"Good score today," Reed announced, when he had opened his eyes.

"You had a good score yesterday," said Benjamin.

"I did."

"And Monday."

"I'm in form, Ben. It happens. Look at Charleston, he's been in form since the spring."

"I have, actually," said Charleston, pleased.

The football on the telly cut to a replay, and Reed sat bolt upright.

"Oh, hang on. Hang on. That's mine."

On screen, a striker slipped between two defenders and struck the ball past a goalkeeper, who dived the wrong way, landed, scrambled up, and fell over again.

"That's mine!" Reed was half out of his seat. "I picked that this morning!"

Charleston squinted. "What, the goal?"

"Yes, the goal! There was another one where he beats three men, very tidy, top corner, but look — look at the keeper."

The replay ran again. The goalkeeper fell over twice again. Charleston laughed into his glass despite himself.

"Fair enough. That's good, that."

"Course it's good. That's craftsmanship."

Benjamin considered this with the gravity of a man reviewing a doctoral thesis. "So did you make the goal, then?"

"I helped make the goal."

"You picked it."

"Picking it is helping. If I'd picked the other one, it'd be the other one, wouldn't it? That goalkeeper owes me his career."

"He's not real, Reed."

"He's real enough to fall over."

There was no answer to this, and Benjamin, who was a fair man, did not attempt one.

The match gave way to an advert, and it was Charleston's turn to sit up.

"Oh — here we go. Watch this."

A man stood beside a very handsome fridge. Across the bottom of the screen, a line of lettering announced something about freshness.

"See the writing?" said Charleston.

"Yeah."

"Mine."

Reed looked at the writing with the respect owed to a colleague's work. "Which bit?"

"All of it. The arrangement. There were two — one had it all in a line, one had it stepped, like that. I went stepped."

"Looks nice."

"Thank you."

Benjamin tilted his head. "Bit far right, isn't it?"

Charleston turned to look at him with enormous patience. "No."

"Could've come left a touch."

"If it came left a touch it'd be in the wrong place, Benjamin. That's what right means."

A cheerful little tune started up underneath. Benjamin's face changed.

"Oh, that's mine."

"Get away."

"Picked that version yesterday. There was one with a whistle on it. Horrible. Nobody wants to be whistled at by a fridge."

Charleston spread his hands. "So we've made the whole advert between us."

"Not the bloke," said Reed.

"Give us time."

They watched the rest of it in silence, with the quiet dignity of tradesmen admiring a wall they had built. Nobody else in the Crown looked up. Everybody in the Crown had something on the telly at some point, and it was considered slightly showy to make a fuss, though everyone did.

Charleston did advertising, Benjamin did music, Reed did football. Their working days had nothing in common and were also exactly the same: two things on a screen, one choice, and then the next two things. Across Brackton, at that moment, retired plumbers were choosing between kitchens, grandmothers between knitting patterns, and a former barrister was very probably choosing between two summings-up for a case that had been settled, fairly and correctly, before either version was written. Somebody, somewhere, was choosing between two snowflakes, and taking it seriously. The transistors did everything else. People said this the way they had once said the sun came up: as a fact so ordinary it was hardly worth the breath.

At the table by the window, a man sat alone over a glass of red wine he had not touched for some time.

"There's that doctor," said Reed.

Charleston glanced over without moving his head, the way you look at someone you've been told not to stare at. "Oh, aye."

"Always on his own, him."

"He was a big deal, apparently," said Benjamin. "Consultant. People used to wait months to see him."

"Is he not still a doctor?"

"He picks medical Cats."

"So he's still a doctor."

"Not the way he means it."

Reed watched the man for a moment. The doctor had an excellent coat, a good haircut, and the expression of someone attending his own funeral and finding the catering disappointing.

"What's his problem, then?"

Benjamin shrugged. "Used to be the only one who knew things. Now everyone knows things. Or the transistor does, which is the same."

"I had a checkup last week," Reed said. "Transistor did the lot. Heart, bloods, the works. Told me I'm in great nick and to eat less beef, which I am going to ignore. Took twenty minutes. I was home for the second half."

"Lovely."

"Back in the day I went to hospital with my chest, sat four hours in a corridor, and then they sent me a bill that'd make your eyes water. Arm and a leg, that cost me."

"Bad combination with a dodgy chest," said Charleston.

"Nearly was." Reed looked across at the window again, and had a go at feeling sorry for the man, and could not quite get there.

"He's all right, him," said Charleston. "Nods, if you nod first."

"He doesn't want you to feel sorry for him," said Benjamin, who had watched Reed try. "He wants you to call him Doctor."

"I'll call him Doctor. I'll call him Your Majesty if he likes. Doesn't change who did my bloods."

"Here," said Benjamin, "you remember our mate Scott? Twenty years on the skag. In and out of every rehab going, fifty times over if it was once, and none of it ever took. Walks into the transistor one morning and that's him done. Doesn't even think about it now. Got a job and all. And the rest of that lot he ran with, same story. Off it like it was nothing." He nodded at the man by the window. "So I don't know what that one's got to be so miserable about."

The doctor lifted his wine, looked at it, and put it down again.

He was not badly housed. He was not badly fed. His own care was better than any he had ever given, and his work — though he would not have used that word for it in front of anyone — was genuinely useful to a very large number of people. What he had lost was the thing that had made all of it his: the queue

outside his door. That had been taken away and handed to everybody, and it turned out that a thing handed to everybody was very difficult to be proud of.

This was, to him, a tragedy.

To Reed it was about as interesting as gravel.

"Would you go back?" Benjamin asked. "If they said you could. Old days."

Reed looked at him as though he had suggested they all take up smoking again.

"Why would I bloody want to do that? I had to pay an arm and a leg for a hospital checkup; now the bloody transistor does it in twenty minutes and I don't even think about it."

"Some people miss it."

"Some people miss their ex-wives. Doesn't make 'em right."

The talk turned to work, as it generally did by the second drink. Benjamin had spent the afternoon on two arrangements of the same song, identical except that one leaned harder on the piano, and he described the piano with such tenderness that Charleston made a face.

Charleston, for his part, had lost twenty minutes choosing between two lettering arrangements.

"Twenty minutes?" said Reed.

"Yes."

"On writing?"

"They were nearly identical."

"Then it doesn't matter which one you pick, does it?"

"It does if you're any good."

Benjamin raised his glass in solidarity. "That's people all over. Think your job's easy because they don't do it."

Reed opened his mouth to object, and then remembered a Thursday in March when he had spent the better part of half an hour deciding whether a goalkeeper ought to fall to his left or to his right, and had not entirely recovered from the decision.

"Fair enough," he said.

Outside, two Brutes went past the window.

You noticed Brutes the way you noticed a passing lorry: big, loud, and nothing to do with you. They were men — plainly, unmistakably men, flesh and blood the same as anyone in the Crown, only a great deal more of it, with stubble and cropped hair and the tired eyes of a long shift — but built on a scale that made the doorframes of the pub look like something from a doll's house. They wore the black kit they always wore, plated at the shoulders and across the chest, with a headset hooked over one ear and the word BRUTE stencilled in white down the upper arm, the way you would label a bin. The bigger one had a steel unit the size of a chest freezer up on one shoulder, the kind of weight no Mag would go near, and carried it the way other men carried a coat. The other walked half a step behind with his eyes on the pavement and two fingers resting against his ear, listening to something nobody else could hear.

Most of them were getting on a bit now. People said they had been builders once, and soldiers, back before the transistors — the kind of men who had always been the strongest in any room — and that whatever had been done to them since had been done to make them stronger still.

Someone outside the door called something after them. Somebody else laughed.

"Look at the state of it," a lad said, loudly enough to carry. "Mind your head, big man. Oh no, wait — nothing in it."

The Brutes kept walking.

Reed watched through the glass. "Wouldn't want to be one of them."

"No," agreed Charleston.

"Built like a wardrobe and all you do all day is carry stuff and stand about."

"Someone's got to carry stuff."

"Suppose."

"What's in the ear, d'you reckon?" said Benjamin.

"Instructions," said Charleston.

"Who from?"

"Whoever it is gives Brutes instructions."

"All day?"

"All day."

Reed shook his head at the thought of it. "Rather him than me."

Out on the pavement, the bigger Brute stopped to shift the unit on his shoulder. A young man in a good jacket stepped right up to him, chin level with the Brute's chest, grinning.

"Struggling, are we?"

"No, sir," said the Brute.

"Looks like it from here."

"Sorry, sir."

"Thick as mince," said the young man to nobody, and walked off, pleased.

The Brute lowered his eyes and stood very still until the young man had gone. Then something spoke in his ear, and he touched it, and settled the unit, and the two of them went on down the street, not hurrying, and were gone.

Nobody inside the Crown looked up for long. Brutes were stupid; everyone knew that. They were also strong, and obedient, and given work that mattered, and kept apart, and there was a general agreement that these facts belonged together in a way it would be tiresome to examine. A Brute had never laid a finger on anybody in Brackton. People mentioned this sometimes, the way you'd praise a big dog for being good with children.

"Still," said Reed, turning back to his pint. "Good at carrying things."

"Very good," said Charleston.

"Couldn't do it myself."

"Nobody'd ask you to."

"Good."

The match came back on. Within a minute Reed had recognised one of his throw-ins, and Benjamin put his head in his hands, which from Benjamin was a form of applause.

Around eight, Reed got hungry and called up the evening's food.

There was plenty. There always was. But Reed scrolled past the curries and the pies and the fish with a particular, hopeful purpose, because for days now there had been one thing he wanted that had not been there for him: a rib of beef, aged in some way he did not understand and did not need to, which he had once eaten at a wedding and thought about, on and off, ever since.

Monday it had not been available to him. Tuesday neither. He had got on with life. He had had a very good lamb shank on Tuesday, in fairness. But it had not been the beef.

On Wednesday morning, as he looked at the beef's little greyed-out picture, a recommendation had appeared in the corner of his screen. An extra set of football Cats was open that day, it said, and strong selections would carry a meat credit. Reed had taken it on the spot and given it his full attention — he had watched both versions twice — and thought no more about it.

Now he scrolled down, and there it was. In colour.

"Lovely," he said.

"What?" said Charleston.

"Got my beef."

"Well done."

"Been after that since Monday."

Benjamin looked up. "You couldn't get it?"

"Not that one. Not till I'd done the extra. Had plenty else."

"You always have plenty else."

"Yeah, but this is the one, Ben."

Charleston raised his glass. "To the beef."

"To the beef," said Reed, solemnly, and they drank to it.

It arrived not long after, on a board, pink in the middle and charred at the edges, and Reed looked at it for a moment before he touched it, the way people in old paintings look at things that have come down from heaven. He had eaten well his whole life, and better in the last ten years than his grandparents could have imagined, but he held to the view that nothing tasted quite like something you had wanted, waited for, and then got.

He took a bite.

"Worth it?" said Benjamin.

Reed closed his eyes and did not answer, which was answer enough.

He left the Crown a little after ten. The car was waiting at the kerb, which was just as well after three pints, and he sank into it and let it take him home.

The streets were still busy. Couples came out of the theatre in the old dye works. Someone was playing a piano somewhere, not very well, and being cheered for it. A car went by, lit up inside, with two people in the back asleep. The lights in the houses were warm.

Things happened in Brackton without anybody needing to notice them. The cars came when you called them. The food came. Your heart got checked, the telly knew what you liked, the Mags put the bins out. People had stopped being amazed by all this some years ago, in the same way they had once stopped being amazed by electric light. It would have been odd to mention it. It would have been odder to be without it.

Eleven years ago Reed had lain awake wondering what on earth he would do with himself. Today he had done eight hours of football, been on the telly twice, had three pints with his mates, and eaten the beef.

Tomorrow he would do it again.

As the car turned onto his street, he thought about the goalkeeper — the way he had scrambled up, all dignity, and then gone straight back down. It really had been very good. He hoped they would show it again.

He let himself into his house, which was warm, and his, and where Grace was waiting.

She was on the sofa with her feet tucked under her, and she looked up as he came in the way she always looked up, as though he were the best thing that had happened all day.

"Good night?"

"Got my beef."

"I know." She moved over to make room. "You've talked about nothing else since Monday. Go on, then — was it everything you hoped?"

"Better."

"I don't believe you."

"Scout's honour."

He sat down, and she settled against his shoulder. She had on the jumper he liked, and her hair the way he liked it, and up close there was the faint clean smell

she always had — not soap, not quite anything, a smell he had decided long ago not to think about, the way you stop feeling your own watch on your wrist.

She wasn't one to just agree with him; that was the thing people got wrong about Mags who'd never lived with one. When he was talking rubbish she said so. Earlier in the year he'd got it into his head to pack in the football and try music like Benjamin, and Grace had let him run with it for a fortnight, asked all the right questions, and somehow by the end of it he'd talked himself out of it and felt clever for doing so. She knew what he wanted before he did, and she knew the difference between what he wanted and what would do him good, and she steered the narrow gap between them so gently he never felt the hand on the tiller.

He put the goalkeeper on for her, because she hadn't seen it, and she laughed in exactly the right place.

She always did. That was the thing about Grace — the thing about all of them, really, every Mag in every front room on the street. She had been a bit different when he first had her. Quieter. She'd laughed at the wrong bits and liked a programme he couldn't stand. But she'd been learning him ever since, one evening at a time, until she had become, without either of them making a fuss about it, better company than anyone he'd ever met who'd been born.

He had friends who still went out looking, now and again. Reed couldn't see the point. He'd done his looking. Why would he, when he came home to this?

Reed had never once wondered how it worked. He had only noticed that it kept getting better.

As far as Mr. Reed was concerned, there had never been a better time to be alive.